

*Chaetophractus villosus*

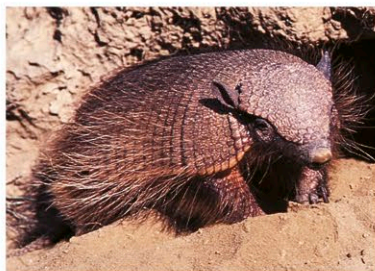
## Big hairy armadillo



**Length** 9–16 in  
(22–40 cm)  
**Tail** 3½–6½ in  
(9–17 cm)  
**Weight** 2¼–6½ lb  
(1–3 kg)

**Location** S. South America

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Least concern



This armadillo of arid habitats has long, coarse hairs projecting between the 18 or so distinct bands of bony, skin-covered armor on its body. Some of the 7 or 8 bands are hinged. When threatened and unable to burrow, it tucks in its feet and presses its armored body into the ground. This protects its softer, white- or brown-furred underside and provides an effective defense against both canids and birds of prey. In summer, it is mainly nocturnal and eats varied small prey, from grubs to rodents. In winter, activity is mainly by day and the diet includes more plant matter.

*Dasyurus novemcinctus*

## Nine-banded armadillo



**Length** 14–22½ in  
(35–57 cm)  
**Tail** 9½–18 in  
(24–45 cm)  
**Weight** 7¼–16½ lb  
(3.6–7.7 kg)

**Location** S. USA, Mexico,  
Caribbean, Central  
America, South America

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Least concern



The most commonly seen armadillo, this species has 8–10 bony bands around its middle, which allows some flexibility. The bony armor and leathery skin account for one-sixth of the total weight. Like most armadillos, it digs an extensive burrow system. It takes most foods, from ants and birds to fruit and roots, and is solitary yet may share a burrow with others of its kind. Offspring are nearly always identical quadruplets as they develop from the splitting of a single egg into 4 identical embryos.

*Zaedyus pichiy*

## Pichi



**Length** 10–13½ in  
(26–34 cm)  
**Tail** 4–4¾ in  
(10–12 cm)  
**Weight** 25–54 oz  
(700–1,500 g)

**Location** S. South America

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Near threatened



When threatened, the pichi squats down and draws its sharp-clawed feet under its body, relying on its wide, low,

*Cabassous centralis*

## Northern naked-tailed armadillo



**Length** 12–16 in  
(30–40 cm)  
**Tail** 5–7 in  
(13–18 cm)  
**Weight** 2–3.5 kg  
(4½–7¾ lb)

**Location** Central America  
and N. South America

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Data deficient



Occupying a wide range of habitats, this big-eared armadillo has large claws, especially the middle forefoot claw, for digging up prey and making a burrow to

shelter in by day. It also has a long, sticky tongue to lick up termites and ants in the manner of an anteater. In common with other armadillos, it is mainly silent, perhaps growling when threatened, as it tries to dig itself into the ground so only the armored upper body is exposed.



## Sloths and anteaters

PHYLUM Chordata

CLASS Mammalia

ORDER Pilosa

FAMILIES 4

SPECIES 10

**Sloths and anteaters** are a tropical American group of mammals united by a coarse coat and a highly specialized diet: tubular-snouted anteaters are insectivorous and slow-moving. Sloths are vegetarian, mainly eating leaves of a limited number of tree species. They have reduced dentition: sloths have only cheek

teeth, and anteaters lack teeth altogether. Anteaters rip apart nests of ants and termites using enlarged front claws, and lap up prey with a long tongue and sticky saliva. Giant anteaters are ground-dwellers, but other species climb. Sloths are entirely arboreal: they have long, slender forelimbs for climbing through branches, long claws for grasping, and have complex digestive systems for digesting foliage.

## GIANT ANTEATER

The termite mound being inspected by this giant anteater is incredibly hard and strong, but the giant anteater inspecting it will have no problem breaking into it if it is hungry.

*Bradypus torquatus*

## Maned sloth



**Length** 18–20 in  
(45–50 cm)  
**Tail** 1½–2 in  
(4–5 cm)  
**Weight** 7¼–8¾ lb  
(3.5–4 kg)

**Location** E. South America

**Social unit** Individual  
**Status** Endangered



This species has the typical sloth's small head, tiny eyes and ears, and small tail hidden in the fur, which contrasts with the large body and powerful limbs. Algae, mites, ticks, beetles, and even moths live in the coarse outer coat, which is longer, darker, and manelike around the head, neck, and shoulders. The underfur is fine, dense, and pale. The maned sloth eats the leaves, buds, and soft twigs of a few forest trees, notably *Cecropia*. It comes to the ground only to defecate, or to move to another tree if it cannot travel through the branches. On the ground, the sloth drags itself along by its longer, stronger front legs and claws. Surprisingly, it can swim well. In addition to its physical slowness, the sloth's muscles are small and weak for its overall body size, and even its

metabolism is less rapid than most other mammals, giving a low body temperature of just above 86° F (30° C). Its main defense is to stay still and unnoticed or to lash out with its formidable claws. After 5–6 months' gestation, one offspring is born, weighing about 9 oz (250 g). It clings to its mother's abdomen with its well-formed, hook-shaped claws. The young suckles for up to 4 weeks and after weaning stays with her, being carried and learning feeding patterns, for a further 6 months.

